The $186 Billion Nobody Stopped

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Federal agencies made roughly $186 billion in improper payments in fiscal year 2025, the Government Accountability Office reported this month. About 82 percent of that sum went to people or programs that should not have received it, most of it overpayments rather than fraud, just dollars that went out the door wrong. The figure rose $24 billion in a single year. That is only the floor.

2 The Agriculture Department runs something called the Emergency Conservation Program, which helps farmers repair land after a flood or a fire. In fiscal 2023 its improper payment rate was 13.5 percent; by fiscal 2024 it was 45.2 percent. **[Juxtaposition]** The rate had climbed above ten percent for four straight years. Unemployment Insurance ran a 14.9 percent error rate and $5.6 billion in improper payments, ninth among the federal programs that miss by more than ten cents on the dollar. The Earned Income Tax Credit, the benefit working families count on at tax time, missed by 32.7 percent: $21.1 billion. Medicaid lost $37 billion. Medicare lost $57 billion in that one year alone.

3 These were not accidents discovered in the dark and corrected by morning. When a program crosses ten percent error for one year, that is a stumble; when it crosses ten percent for two years, that is a pattern; when seven agencies cross ten percent for two or more consecutive years, that is a decision, repeated, by people who knew. **[Parallelism]** The Treasury knew. Veterans Affairs knew. Labor knew. Agriculture knew. Health and Human Services knew. Education knew. The Corporation for National and Community Service knew. **[Epistrophe]** Five of those seven did not even keep the documented policies that would let them report the failure on time.

4 Since 2003, federal agencies have made an estimated $3 trillion in improper payments. Three trillion dollars is not a scandal that broke this week; it is the slow weather of two decades. **[Metaphor]** It is the cost of every year the watchdog filed its report and the same programs filed the same numbers. The five largest programs alone accounted for about $128 billion of last year's total, two-thirds of the whole.

5 We funded all of it. The agencies whose budgets are our taxes, the abstract Treasury, those are not who pays in the end; the household that filed on time pays, and the worker whose check was light. **[Antithesis]** The watchdog has done its job. It counted, it named, it published the rates and the years and the agencies. The rest is not the GAO's to fix. It belongs to the seven agencies that have now been told, in writing, for years, exactly where the money goes.

Devices, and why they are here:

Juxtaposition (paragraph 2): “In fiscal 2023 its improper payment rate was 13.5 percent; by fiscal 2024 it was 45.2 percent.”
Setting the 13.5 percent rate directly against the 45.2 percent rate forces the reader to feel the climb rather than be told it is alarming; the bare numbers side by side carry the indictment, keeping pathos inside the fact as the register requires.

Parallelism (paragraph 3): “When a program crosses ten percent error for one year, that is a stumble; when it crosses ten percent for two years, that is a pattern; when seven agencies cross ten percent for two or more consecutive years, that is a decision, repeated, by people who knew.”
The three escalating when-clauses (one year, two years, seven agencies) build the moral case through repeated grammatical structure, turning a statistical threshold into a verdict that gathers weight and lands on the word decision.

Epistrophe (paragraph 3): “The Treasury knew. Veterans Affairs knew. Labor knew. Agriculture knew. Health and Human Services knew. Education knew. The Corporation for National and Community Service knew.”
Repeating the word knew at the END of each successive clause, after a different agency name opens each one, turns a flat list of institutions into a drumbeat verdict; the closing repetition pins awareness onto each named body and denies the reader the comfort of a faceless system.

Metaphor (paragraph 4): “Since 2003, federal agencies have made an estimated $3 trillion in improper payments. Three trillion dollars is not a scandal that broke this week; it is the slow weather of two decades.”
Calling $3 trillion the slow weather of two decades compresses the abstraction of cumulative waste into a single concrete image of something continuous and unstopped, doing the work an emotive adjective would otherwise do.

Antithesis (paragraph 5): “The agencies whose budgets are our taxes, the abstract Treasury, those are not who pays in the end; the household that filed on time pays, and the worker whose check was light.”
Setting the abstract Treasury against the household that filed on time and the worker whose check was light cashes out who actually pays, fusing the dollar figure with a human cost and implicating the reader as both funder and victim.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the second paragraph, the writer presents the programs in an order of increasing magnitude, from the obscure Emergency Conservation Program up to Medicare, primarily to

A) prove that smaller federal programs are managed far more carelessly than the larger ones
B) arrange the examples so each carries higher stakes than the last, making the scale felt first
C) suggest the Earned Income Tax Credit is the most poorly run program in government
D) establish that improper payments are confined to a few unusually troubled federal agencies

2. In the third paragraph, the repetition of "knew" at the end of each clause naming an agency most directly serves to

A) assign responsibility to each named institution rather than to a faceless system
B) soften the accusation by spreading blame thinly across many bodies
C) question whether the agencies were aware of their own error rates
D) concede that the agencies faced obstacles beyond their control

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer B. The paragraph climbs from an obscure program with a 45.2 percent rate to Medicare's $57 billion, so the dollar figures grow with each example and the reader feels the magnitude before the generalization arrives. The option claiming smaller programs are run more carelessly inverts the passage, which presents the small program as worse by rate but the large ones as worse by dollars, not a claim about size and care. The option naming the EITC as the worst program overstates a single cited rate the text never ranks first. The option that improper payments are confined to a few agencies contradicts the $186 billion total and the seven-agency finding, importing a narrowing the passage rejects.

2. Answer A. Naming Treasury, Veterans Affairs, Labor and the rest in turn, each closing on knew, pins accountability on specific bodies and denies the reader an abstract culprit, which is the paragraph's whole move toward the word decision. The concession option reverses the tone; the passage grants the agencies no obstacles and treats the failure as chosen. The softening option misreads the effect, since naming each body separately concentrates blame rather than diluting it. The option about questioning awareness contradicts the flat assertion that they knew, reading doubt into a sentence built on certainty.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer insists the $186 billion figure is "only the floor." What does the piece treat as the actual failure, and how does the structure of the second paragraph build toward that distinction?

2. The closing paragraph shifts from naming agencies to naming "the household that filed on time and the worker whose check was light." How does that shift change who the reader understands to be harmed, and why might the writer save it for the end?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The failure is not the size of the waste but its repetition. The second paragraph escalates from a tiny program with a 45.2 percent error rate to Medicare's $57 billion, which makes the dollar amounts climb, but the third paragraph reframes the real charge: a program crossing ten percent once is a stumble, twice is a pattern, and seven agencies crossing it for consecutive years is a decision. The writer uses the rising examples to set up that distinction, so by the time the word decision lands, the reader already feels that the problem is not one bad year but an institution choosing not to fix itself.

2. By ending on the household and the worker, the writer converts an abstract budget number into a personal cost and makes the reader one of the harmed parties rather than a spectator. The antithesis between the abstract Treasury and the worker whose check was light cashes out the earlier statistics into a human stake. Saving it for the close gives the charge its force: the piece has spent four paragraphs establishing scale and responsibility, so the final move, that this belongs to the agencies the reader has funded, lands as an obligation the reader cannot pass off, because the reader has just been named as the one who paid.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that the central failure in federal improper payments is not the dollar amount but the repetition: agencies that crossed a ten percent error rate for multiple consecutive years without correcting course. Some would counter that error rates in programs as large and complex as Medicare or the Earned Income Tax Credit are an unavoidable cost of delivering benefits at national scale, and that a low percentage of a huge number will always look enormous in dollars. Write an essay in which you defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that persistent improper payment rates above ten percent should be treated as institutional failure rather than the ordinary friction of running large programs. Use reasoning and your own knowledge or examples to support your position; you need not accept the writer's framing.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the piece as an attack on government spending or on the programs themselves (Medicaid, the EITC), when the writer's charge is narrower: the failure is uncorrected error over consecutive years, and several of the named programs are described as benefits families depend on.
- Students may treat epistrophe and parallelism as the same device. In paragraph three the agency-name-plus-"knew" run is epistrophe because the repeated element, knew, closes each clause while a different agency opens it; the escalating "when... when... when" structure is parallelism because matched grammar, not a fixed word at one end, is doing the work. Watch the look-alike trap: repetition at the start of clauses would be anaphora, but here the repeated word lands at the end.
- Students may call the "slow weather of two decades" a simile because it describes a comparison; it is a metaphor, since it states that the $3 trillion is the weather rather than saying it is like weather. The absence of "like" or "as" is the test.
- Students may assume the 82 percent overpayment detail or the EITC figure is the emotional climax because it is striking, when the writer deliberately keeps emotion inside the plain numbers and reserves the human cost for the antithesis in the final paragraph; mistaking a vivid statistic for the argument's peak misreads where the piece actually turns.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches escalating exemplification as a structural engine: how a writer orders examples by rising stakes so scale is felt before it is asserted, and how that climb sets up a reframing turn (waste as repeated decision rather than one bad year). It also drills the look-alike distinction between epistrophe and parallelism within a single paragraph and the simile-versus-metaphor test, while showing how a writer can keep pathos inside concrete numbers and a named human cost rather than emotive adjectives. The Q3 prompt extends the passage's contestable claim into an argument students must defend, challenge, or qualify.